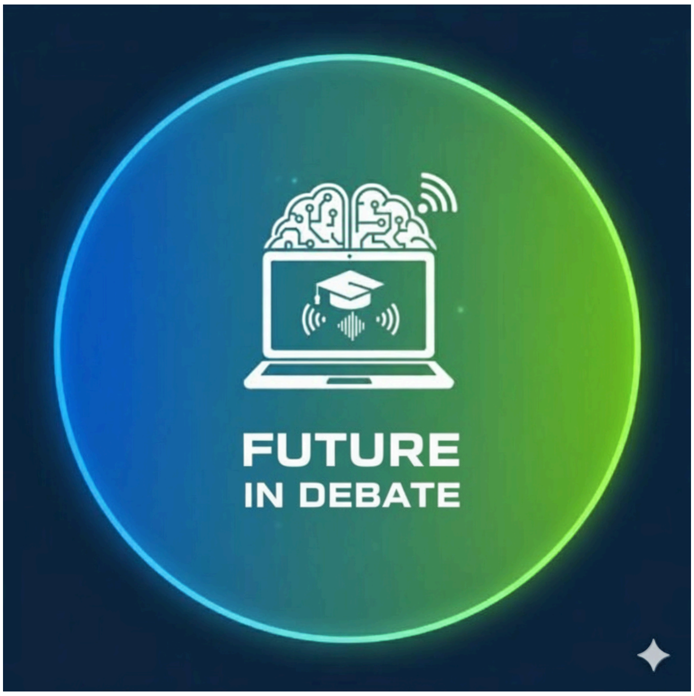
Jorge Llamas, Nicolás García-Sampedro Docampo, Álvaro Santos y Chao An Alarcón



PODCAST:

“Future in Debate”

Jorge Llamas, Nicolás García-Sampedro Docampo, Álvaro Santos y Chao An Alarcón

Futuristic Cities

Roles:

- Against: **Nicolás**
- Against and Neutral: **Chao** (Introduce the rest)
- For: **Álvaro**
- For and Neutral: **Jorge**

Arguments:

Jorge and Álvaro (For):

Arguments **For** Futuristic Cities:

- Faster, cleaner, and more accessible mass transportation systems.
- Streets adapted for bicycles and pedestrians, promoting active mobility
- Autonomous vehicles that reduce accidents and improve traffic flow.
- Significant reduction of environmental pollution thanks to clean energy technologies integrated into urban infrastructure.
- Facilitates social inclusion and accessibility for people with reduced mobility through universal urban design.

Nico and Chao (Against):

Arguments **Against** Futuristic Cities:

- The government will have all of our personal data, the citizens won't have privacy at all.
- Citizens will live in a world where they can't be truly free.
- Overly technological cities may lose cultural identity and feel alienating.
- Social inequality: futuristic benefits could serve only a few, leaving the rest behind.
- Extreme tech dependence: if AI or connected systems fail, the whole city could shut down.
- More sensors and connectivity mean greater vulnerability to cyberattacks.
- Some solutions (vertical farms, desalination) require massive energy or have hidden impacts.
- Building these cities already creates a massive initial carbon footprint.
- What feels "futuristic" today can quickly become obsolete.

Timeline Structure:

INTRO:

- **Chao:**
  Welcome to "Future in Debate"! Today we're diving into one of the most fascinating and controversial ideas of our time: futuristic cities. Imagine walking through streets with no traffic, where electric cars glide silently and public transport is so efficient that owning a car feels unnecessary. Buildings would generate their own energy through solar panels, wind turbines, or even kinetic floors that capture footsteps. Robots would deliver packages, drones would monitor safety, and everything around you would be connected in real time. A city that learns, adapts, and responds to its citizens.
  But here's the question: will all this technology really make us happier, freer, and safer — or could it end up controlling us?
  Joining me today are my friends and fellow debaters: Álvaro, Nico, and Jorge. Together, we'll explore the promises and dangers of this high-tech urban future, from transport to privacy, and from social life to sustainability.

  Ampliación - You might be wondering: why does this matter now? Cities are where most of the world lives, works and dreams — and what we build today will shape the next fifty years. Small design choices — where we put a bus stop, whether we fund a community garden, or how we handle a single data stream — ripple into lives and livelihoods. So this conversation isn't just speculation; it's about rules, values and who benefits.

  In this episode we'll try to keep things practical: real examples, realistic risks, and equally realistic solutions. We'll argue, disagree, and hopefully leave listeners with concrete ideas to take back to their neighbourhoods.

MAKE SELF INTRODUCTIONS

For example, "I am Nicolás García-Sampedro Docampo and I am Web Development Student in Nebrija".

PART 1: Transport and Safety

- **Chao:**
  Let's begin with one of the most visible aspects of a futuristic city: how people move. Transportation defines urban life. Álvaro, how do you think future mobility will shape our cities?

- **Álvaro (FOR - transportation and mobility):**
  For me, the most exciting part about futuristic cities is the transformation of mobility. Imagine a city where every transport system — trains, buses, cars, and even bikes — are connected through one network that prevents delays and accidents. Instead of traffic jams, we'd have real-time coordination, with AI predicting when and where congestion will happen before it does. Electric and hydrogen-powered vehicles would make transportation almost emission-free. Even flying taxis could become normal, cutting hours from long commutes.
  And beyond that, the entire design of cities would change. Streets wouldn't be ruled by cars anymore — they'd be spaces for people. We'd see green boulevards, urban forests, bike highways, and wide pedestrian zones where you can walk, socialize, and enjoy nature without noise or pollution. Technology would make cities not just more efficient, but more livable.

  Ampliación - To make it concrete, picture Maria — a nurse living in the suburbs. Today she spent two hours commuting. In a connected system, an app bundles her route: a neighborhood shuttle leaves when ten people in her block need it; the tram adjusts speed to meet transfer windows; and a quick micro-e-bike completes the last mile. That saves her time, reduces stress and lowers emissions.

Another aspect is inclusivity: transport should adapt to mobility needs. Elevators, tactile paving and audible signals for visually impaired people must be part of the plan from day one — not added later as an afterthought. In many current systems accessibility is patched on; futuristic design should reverse that.

Finally, talk about real pilots: cities starting with small corridors or districts — test the tech, measure user satisfaction and safety, then scale. That reduces risk and builds public trust.

- **Nico (AGAINST):**
  That sounds ideal, but it hides a dangerous dependency on technology. If everything is automated, what happens when something fails? A single cyberattack could cause chaos, stop public transport, or even lock people inside automated vehicles. We've seen how even small software errors can cause major problems in real systems. Now imagine that at the scale of an entire city.
  Also, automation comes with social consequences. Drivers, mechanics, and even public transport workers could lose their jobs. And as cities become more digital, they also become less private. Every trip, every location, every movement could be tracked. The idea of total connectivity might make life easier, but it also risks turning citizens into data points.

  Ampliación - Let 's personalise the risk. Imagine Luis, a taxi driver who's worked nights for 15 years. One month a new autonomous fleet rolls into his city and demand drops sharply. Luis faces sudden income loss. Retraining programs exist in theory, but how long until he can pay rent? These human stories are often missing from glossy plans.

  Also, consider cascading failures: if the public transport brain goes offline during a heatwave, the combination of stalled transport and extreme weather is a real public-safety crisis.

Designing for those edge cases — manual override centers, local fallback procedures, and community alert systems — is essential.

- **Chao:**
  That's a good point, Nico. Jorge, what do you think? Can technology truly make transport and safety better, or are we going too far?

- **Jorge (FOR - technology and safety):**
  I believe technology can make our cities safer and more efficient if we apply it responsibly. Autonomous vehicles are already being tested, and they show huge potential for reducing human error, which causes most traffic accidents. AI-based traffic systems could manage intersections to prevent collisions and reduce waiting times. Cameras, sensors, and drones could monitor roads in real time to alert authorities instantly about any emergencies. Plus, automation doesn't have to mean job loss. It can create new roles — for example, technicians maintaining autonomous systems, software engineers, and city analysts. And if governments plan properly, they can retrain workers to adapt to these new opportunities.

  Ampliación - On liability: we need clear legal frameworks. If an autonomous vehicle injures someone, who answers? The car company, the software vendor, the city authority? Until laws assign responsibility clearly, adoption will be uneven and litigation will slow progress. A phased legal approach — temporary rules for pilots, then formal liability laws — helps.

  And practically, public engagement matters: town-hall demonstrations, clear educational videos and simple FAQs can demystify the tech. The more people understand, the less fear-driven resistance we'll face.

- **Chao (AGAINST):**
  That sounds optimistic, but we can't assume everything will work

perfectly. Security breaches don't just depend on machines but on people with bad intentions. Imagine someone hacking into traffic systems and causing accidents intentionally, or manipulating routes for personal gain. The more we automate, the more we centralize control. It's like giving someone the keys to an entire city.

- **Jorge (FOR):**
  I see your concern, but we shouldn't let fear stop progress. Every major innovation had risks at the start — electricity, airplanes, the internet. What matters is building safeguards. And remember, technology doesn't just improve transport — it can revolutionize healthcare. Picture hospitals that can predict disease outbreaks, ambulances guided by AI to the fastest routes, and patients whose vital signs are monitored 24/7 through smart wearables. This could save millions of lives. The future city, if designed ethically, could be the safest environment humans have ever lived in.

PART 2: Privacy and Social Impact

- **Chao:**
  Let's move to another huge topic: privacy. In futuristic cities, everything from traffic to trash collection would be monitored. Nico, I know you're skeptical about this. Why?

- **Nico (AGAINST – privacy and freedom):**
  Because it sounds like the perfect surveillance trap. Imagine cameras on every corner, sensors on every building, and algorithms analyzing everything we do. Governments and companies could track every movement, purchase, and interaction. Even if it's meant to improve efficiency, the data could easily be used for control. Who guarantees it won't be misused? A perfectly organized city could easily become a perfectly controlled one.

Ampliación - Consider a scenario where collected behavioural data is used to automate public services — but also sold to advertisers. That dual use creates incentives to collect ever more sensitive information. The solution? Law must require use-specific data collection: collect only what's strictly needed for a single public purpose and prohibit secondary commercial uses unless explicitly consented to by users. Public procurement contracts should include these clauses.

We also need transparency tools: simple dashboards where citizens can see what sensors exist in their neighbourhood, what they collect, and who has access. Transparency builds accountability.

- **Álvaro (FOR):**
  You're right, that risk exists. But it's not technology that causes it, it's bad management. We could use decentralized systems that store data locally instead of in government databases. Privacy-by-design could make personal data secure from the start. Also, the benefits of these systems — reduced crime, faster emergency response, and better resource management — can be life-changing if done transparently.

  Ampliación - Technically, edge processing is powerful: cameras can send only anonymised counts (e.g., "12 people entered") rather than faces. Differential privacy can add noise so individuals cannot be re-identified. And independent audits — third-party technical reviews — are not optional; they should be part of any smart-city contract.

  Finally, community control models exist: municipal data trusts where the city manages data on behalf of residents, with citizen representatives on oversight boards. These models shift power away from private vendors and back to the public.

- **Chao (AGAINST – social and cultural impact):**
  That's fair, but we can't ignore the social inequalities. These

systems would cost billions to build. Rich neighborhoods would get the newest tech and clean infrastructure, while poorer areas might remain outdated. Technology could divide cities into two realities — those who live in the future and those left in the past. Instead of connecting society, futuristic cities could deepen inequality.

- **Jorge (FOR):**
  Unless we use technology as a tool for inclusion. Governments could use smart city planning to target help where it's most needed: improving air quality in poor districts, providing public Wi-Fi, or offering digital education. The goal should be equality through innovation. It's not automatic, but with the right policies, it's possible.

- **Nico (AGAINST):**
  Maybe, but we could also lose something less visible: our cultural identity. Cities full of holograms and smart screens could look clean but soulless. Traditional markets, street art, human noise — all replaced by digital perfection. Even worse, if the network collapses, everything could fall apart. Ironically, a city designed to protect nature could harm it because of the rare materials and massive energy needed to maintain all this technology.

PART 3: Possible Solutions

- **Álvaro (FOR):**
  I agree that these issues are real, but technology can also help solve them. Smart cities can use data to protect culture, not erase it — like promoting local festivals through digital platforms or preserving historical buildings with 3D scanning and AR tours. Regarding the environment, while building these cities requires resources, they're meant to give more back over time: producing renewable energy, recycling water, and managing waste sustainably.

Ampliación - Beyond policies, we need measurable KPIs: reduced commute time by X%, air-quality improvement by Y, and demonstrable employment transition targets. Contracts should include penalty clauses if vendors fail to meet social or environmental KPIs. That turns good intentions into enforceable obligations.

Also, create 'innovation sandboxes' — legal spaces where new systems can be trialed with waivers, but only under strict conditions and oversight. These sandboxes accelerate learning without risking whole-city deployments.

- **Nico (AGAINST):**
  That's a noble vision, but often what we see in practice is greenwashing — making things look sustainable when they're not. Corporations claim their tech is saving the planet while their factories pollute elsewhere. And culturally, it's easy to say tech helps art, but algorithms mostly promote what's popular, not what's meaningful. Futuristic cities could end up prioritizing profit and convenience over creativity and humanity.

  Ampliación - To avoid greenwashing, require supply-chain transparency. If a company claims zero emissions for a new district, they must publish manufacturing and shipping emissions for materials used. Independent environmental auditors should verify these claims. Otherwise, the carbon footprint is simply outsourced.

  Cultural protection also needs funding: create line items in city budgets for local artists, markets, and festivals — not just as one-offs, but as permanent allocations. If culture is valued formally in the budget, it survives modernization.

- **Jorge (FOR):**
  I think progress always comes with tension between ideals and reality. The challenge isn't avoiding technology but guiding it with ethical design and long-term vision. Renewable energy, smart

grids, and intelligent water systems could make cities self-sufficient. The future doesn't have to erase culture; it can amplify it through global sharing. Imagine visiting digital museums that preserve endangered traditions forever.

PART 4: The Role of People in Futuristic Cities

- **Chao:**
  We've talked about systems and structures, but what about the people? At the end of the day, cities exist for citizens. So, what role should humans play in shaping these high-tech environments? Let's talk about participation, remote work, and the idea of the 15-minute city, where everything is within reach.

- **Álvaro (FOR):**
  I believe people must stay at the center of innovation. Technology should serve them, not replace them. Citizens could use apps to vote on city projects, suggest improvements, or track budgets transparently. The 15-minute city idea is brilliant: living, working, and relaxing within walking distance creates stronger communities and reduces stress. Remote work can also give people more time for family, hobbies, and self-development instead of wasting hours in traffic.

  Ampliación - Practical civic tools matter: easy-to-use platforms where residents can propose micro-projects (like a park bench or community garden) and request small grants. These tools should be multilingual and low-bandwidth friendly so older residents or people with limited internet can participate. Small, frequent wins build trust faster than grand promises.

- **Nico (AGAINST):**
  That's great in theory, but remote work can also make people feel lonely and disconnected. Cafes, restaurants, and small shops that depend on office workers could struggle. Also, 15-minute cities

can raise property prices, making central areas unaffordable. And digital participation often feels symbolic — like pressing a button but not being truly heard.

Ampliación - Address loneliness and hollowing-out with policy: subsidised local co-working hubs and cultural events tied to neighborhoods can keep economic activity local. When companies endorse remote work, they should be encouraged to support local coworking memberships for employees — a small tax incentive for employers can help. That keeps money flowing locally and provides social points of contact for remote workers.

- **Jorge (FOR):**
  Those are valid points, but the key is balance. Governments should mix online and real participation — like open assemblies or hybrid town halls. If housing remains affordable and neighborhoods stay diverse, these cities can build stronger communities. Technology can connect citizens to decision-making like never before. Remote work, if done right, can even repopulate rural towns, giving them new economic life.

  Ampliación - A strong policy mix can push people to choose smaller towns: remote-incentive packages (grants for coworking spaces in rural areas), investments in regional transport, and tax breaks for companies hiring remote staff in non-urban regions. Over time, this diversifies economic geography and reduces pressure on mega-cities, if done alongside quality-of-life investments — good schools, healthcare, and cultural facilities.

CLOSING – Group Discussion

- **Chao:**
  We're reaching the end of our debate. What have we learned today?

- **Álvaro:**
  Futuristic cities could offer cleaner air, smarter systems, and sustainable living. They could make life more efficient and comfortable.

- **Jorge:**
  But technology alone won't solve every problem. The real challenge will be using it wisely, ensuring fairness, and keeping human needs first.

- **Nico:**
  Exactly. A city full of automation isn't better if people feel isolated or constantly watched. True progress means preserving freedom, privacy, and humanity.

- **Chao:**
  Well said. Maybe the perfect city isn't the one with the most technology, but the one that knows how to combine progress with empathy, innovation with culture, and data with dignity.

- **Chao (closing):**
  That wraps up this episode of "Future in Debate." Thanks for listening! Remember, the future isn't something that happens to us — it's something we build, choice by choice, together.